

The Fragile Ceasefire Holds — Barely — As Heatwaves and War Strain Every System

A week that began with US-Iran reciprocal strikes ended with indirect talks in Doha producing a communication channel but no breakthrough, while the Islamabad MoU's 60-day ceasefire entered its third week under constant strain. Russia unleashed its largest barrage on Kyiv, Ukraine struck deep into St Petersburg, and record heatwaves killed thousands across two continents simultaneously. The US Supreme Court reshaped presidential power, the USMCA expired into annual uncertainty, and Gaza passed 1,000 days of devastation.

The Bottom Line

The week's dominant pattern was fragility across every domain. The US-Iran ceasefire survived its second weekend of reciprocal strikes and produced its first tangible mechanism — a communication channel in Doha — but the core disputes over Hormuz control, nuclear inspections, and a permanent deal remain unresolved, with the 60-day clock running. Russia demonstrated its willingness to escalate with the largest barrage on Kyiv of the war, even as Ukraine struck St Petersburg's oil infrastructure and Russia's fuel crisis deepened to the point where Putin had to acknowledge it publicly. The US Supreme Court gave presidents historic new power over independent agencies — then used conservative justices to constrain Trump on the Fed, birthright citizenship, and elections. Record heatwaves killed thousands across two continents simultaneously, shutting down national celebrations and straining grids. The USMCA expired into annual reviews, and Canada locked in a pipeline to redirect oil away from the US. Gaza passed 1,000 days of devastation. Venezuela's earthquake toll surpassed 2,200. And Poland publicly warned of a Russian provocation days before NATO's Ankara summit. Across every theatre — military, legal, climatic, diplomatic — temporary arrangements are being tested by pressures they were never designed to contain.